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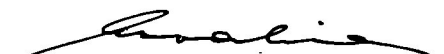
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Major airports in India have become nightmares. At peak hours, there is total chaos with overcrowded terminals, endless queues, frayed tempers and missed flights. Recently, in Delhi, it took me 45 minutes to enter the international airport and another 3 hours to check in, clear immigration and security to board the plane. Mumbai is no better. Both in Delhi and Mumbai, which account for 60 per cent of the air traffic, the desperately needed upgrade and expansion of the airports are being done in live conditions where routine activities and movements continue. I have travelled through the new or upgraded airports in South East Asia: Bangkok, Hong Kong, Shanghai, Singapore and seen them do it without affecting normal passenger traffic. We seem to have a knack for creating chaos where none exists.

Admittedly, passenger traffic here has shot up in recent years thanks to the advent of low cost airlines but that was easy to predict. Aviation has been the fastest growing sector of Indian industry for some time. With more airlines operating and a massive increase in traffic, the crush was inevitable and is now taxing every aspect of airport operations, from safety and security to passenger facilities. Infrastructure is outdated and insufficient. Delhi operates at 200 per cent capacity and was built to handle 13 million passengers annually. It handled 23 million in 2007.

The key problem is that area of the airport which comes under the government: security which includes immigration services and air traffic control. Immigration counters, under the Home Ministry, are the single biggest bottlenecks at Indian airports because they are perpetually undermanned and they treat every passenger as a potential terrorist. The crush is literally killing: every day there are reports of power failures or deaths due to negligence and speeding on runways. The lack of space for expansion in Mumbai means problems will continue even after the new airport is ready in three years' time. The option of having two airports in one city is stuck in archaic rules which stipulate a distance of 150 km between them. Heathrow to Gatwick airport is 69 km by road and 39.8 km as the crow flies. Our big cities need multiple airports with easy access.

Our cover story looks at the problems bedevilling our airports. We evaluate the worst and the best, fathom what is required to get them up to international standards, and whether there is any hope for our much-harried air passengers. Here is an India screaming to the world its economic growth story, its emergence as a global power and the first and the last impression that an outsider gets of us is of our pathetic airports where arrival or departure is an ordeal in itself. The blame lies squarely on the authorities' lack of planning and coordination in not seeing the obvious—too many flights and too few facilities. It's time they fixed it, or with the summer holidays the situation will become unbearable and will continue being a blot on our international image.


(Aroon Purie)